OTT

Drama in UNIFORM

NEERAJ PANDEY HAS MANAGED TO ROPE IN THE LEADING STARS OF BANGLA CINEMA FOR NETFLIX'S *KHAKEE: THE BENGAL CHAPTER*

Even before *Khakee: The Bihar Chapter* (2022) became one of Netflix's most popular Indian originals, its creator Neeraj Pandey knew he wanted it to be a franchise, one that could travel to a new state each season. With the viewership defying expectations, Pandey got the green signal.

In its second run, Pandey has a homecoming of sorts, having set the show in Kolkata, where he grew up. "Everything has changed now and in a way nothing has changed too," says Pandey, who was raised in Howrah. "I find that dichotomy every time I come here, that's the beauty of Cal [Calcutta]."

And he has managed a coup of sorts, having roped in Prosenjit Chatterjee and Jeet, two immensely popular stars of Bangla cinema, to act together for the first time. While the veteran Chatterjee plays





CALCUTTA CALLING (Top) Aakanksha Singh and Jeet in Khakee: *The Bengal Chapter*; left, Prosenjit Chatterjee in the series

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GUY NEXT DOOR

Nikhil Madhok is bringing his brand of relatable programming to Amazon Prime India as its head of original content

Nikhil Madhok, Head of Originals, Amazon Prime India, has had a busy first quarter. There's been the well-received season two of *Paatal Lok* (January); the moving father-son drama, *The Mehta Boys*; the tale on passionate cinephiles in *Superboys of Malegaon* (February), and the slice-of-life comedy in *Duphaiya*. "The best part of my job is that typically by a Sunday or Monday, I get a call from a talent, in front or behind the camera, and they are like 'I've never experienced this in my life,'" says Madhok. "That one call brings so much joy. It makes the two-three years of work spent making it [show or film] worthwhile."

Madhok started out with a marketing stint in Unilever before moving to where his heart lay—in "storytelling". He joined NDTV Imagine and then the programming team of Star before becoming a key member of its digital iteration, HotStar. Madhok made an impression spearheading HotStar specials like *Aarya* and *Special Ops*. It was his work here that would land him a call from Gaurav Gandhi to be the head of Hindi originals at Amazon Prime in 2022. "The way Amazon focuses on storytelling, long-term thinking and customer obsession is special," he adds. With the departure of Aparna Purohit last year, Madhok was elevated to head of original content. Eight months into the job, series like *Call Me Bae* and *Duphaiya* bear his creative imprint. Amazon Prime India has also announced a desi version of the game show, *The Traitors*, to be hosted by Karan Johar, and a first-of-its-kind attempt to produce a film based on an existing franchise in *Mirzapur*. Says Madhok, "I believe that it'd